Guide to the APSA Citation Format

Emily Cottle Ommundsen*

May 15, 2024

APSA (American Political Science Association) format is an in-text, parenthetical citation method like MLA or APA format. APSA is an easy and relatively logical format to follow. Each time you rely on an idea, fact, or quotation from an outside source, you must include an in-text parenthetical citation. For each source you cite in the text, you should provide bibliographic information on an alphabetized reference page. It is easy for the reader to follow your sources because the in-text citation is based on the first words in the reference page entry — either the author's last name or an abbreviated title (when an author is not listed).

Please note that if you use reference management software to generate your reference list in APSA format, it is your responsibility to edit the list to ensure correct information and formatting — reference software frequently makes serious errors!

REFERENCE PAGE

The reference page is a list of sources *actually cited* in the text. It is alphabetized by the first word in each entry, and the entries are not numbered. The reference page should be titled "References" (not "Works Cited"). Here are examples of entries for common types of sources:

Books

Skowronek, Stephen. 1997. *The Politics Presidents Make: Leadership from John Adams to Bill Clinton.* Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press.

Chapters in Edited Books

Evans, C. Lawrence and Claire E. Grandy. 2009. "The Whip Systems of Congress." In *Congress Reconsidered*, 9th edition, eds. Lawrence C. Dodd and Bruce I. Oppenheimer. Washington, DC: CQ Press.

Articles in Academic Journals

(Numbers after the journal title are volume, issue, and pages)

Meinke, Scott R. 2008. "Who Whips? Party Government and the Expansion of House Whip Networks." *American Politics Research* 36(5):639-668.

*emilyommundsen@gmail.com. From the APSA *Style Manual for Political Science, 2006* and Prof. Scott Meinke's guide.

Articles in Newspapers

Liptak, Adam. 2013. "Court Takes Case On Overall Limit In Election Cash." *New York Times*, February 20.

Articles in Magazines

(Number after month/day is page number, if available)

Brownstein, Ronald. 2013. "A Millennial Moment." *National Journal*, February 16, 6.

Articles in Newspapers or Magazines, no author given

Congressional Quarterly Weekly Report. 1985. "Today's Whip: Not Just Keeping the Pack in Line." November 30.

Government Documents

U.S. Congress. 1975. *The History and Operation of the House Majority Whip Organization*. 94th Cong., 1st Session, H. Doc. 94-162.

Online sources, author given

(Note that the first date is the date the article originally appeared or was revised, if available, and the date at the end is the date that you accessed it online.)

Allen, Mike and Josh White. 2004. "President Outlines Overseas Troop Cut," *Washington Post*, August 17. http://www.washingtonpost.com/wp-dyn/articles/A6461-2004Aug16.html (August 19, 2004).

Lane, Moe. 2008. "Biden to Pennsylvania: No Coal for You," RedState.com, September 23. http://www.redstate.com/diaries/redstate/2008/sep/23/biden-to-pennsylvania-no-coal-for-you/ (September 24, 2008).

Online sources, no author given

(Note that the first date is the date the article originally appeared or was revised, if available, and the date at the end is the date that you accessed it online.)

FOXNews.com. 2008. "Religious Groups Condemn 'Obscene' Event Honoring Ahmadinejad," September 24. http://www.foxnews.com/story/0,2933,427024,00.html (September 26, 2008).

American Conservative Union. 2012. "2011 U.S. House Votes." http://conservative.org/ratingsarchive/uscongress/2011/house.html (February 20, 2013).

U.S. Census Bureau. 2010. "Fast Facts for Congress." http://www.census.gov/fastfacts/ (February 20, 2013).

IN-TEXT CITATIONS

Include an in-text citation whenever you draw on any information or ideas from an outside source. Do not use footnotes for citations. The following rules and examples explain how to do this.

(1) When you cite a source that has a listed author(s), your citation should include the last name(s) and year of publication. If you are citing a webpage, the in-text citation date should be the date of publication/update (if available).

> *Example*: Bill Clinton's political agenda attempted to challenge the dominant political regime while simultaneously adopting some of its key elements (Skowronek 1997).

(2) When you cite a source that does not have a listed author(s), your citation should refer to the publication/website name and year.

> *Example*: Representative Smith's constituents are well-educated; 45% of the district's adults hold a college degree (U.S. Census Bureau 2010).

(3) When you quote directly from a source OR borrow a specific idea found in one section of a print source, your citation should include the page number(s) where the quotation or idea is found.

> *Example*: As one scholar has argued, presidential politics in the late 20th century may have been entering an era of "perpetual preemption" (Skowronek 1997, 444).

(4) If you have already mentioned the authors and/or publication year of a work as you discuss it, you need not repeat that information in the citation.

> *Example 1*: Skowronek (1997) presents an American political development view of presidential power.
>
> *Example 2*: As Skowronek claimed in 1997, presidential politics is entering an era of "perpetual preemption" (444).

FAQS

- *How do I cite and reference multiple works by the same author from the same year?* Place a different letter after the year of each reference page entry from the same author-year (1981a, 1981b, etc.), and cite in-text accordingly (Smith 1981a) to differentiate.
- *What if all of the information in a paragraph is from the same source?* You can simply cite that source once at the very end of the paragraph, unless you are specifically referencing different pages through the paragraph.
- *How do I cite multiple sources for the same idea?* Include all of the sources in the same parenthetical citation, and order them alphabetically (Allen and White 2004; Auletta 2004).
- *What if a source has multiple authors? Do I have to include all of their names?* For three or fewer, use all of the names in the citation. For four or more, you can abbreviate

(Smith et al. 2003). But always include all of the authors' names in the reference page listing.

- *Does punctuation go before or after the parenthetical citation?* At the end of a sentence, the period (question mark, etc.) goes after the citation. However, if you are citing at the end of a quotation, the closed-quotation marks go before the citation and period.
- *What if there isn't a title for a web source?* If you are citing a page that does not have a title or obvious heading, use the title/heading that appears in the tab or bar at the top of your browser window.
- *What about court cases?* Cite in-text using the case name and year of decision (*Baker* v. *Carr* 1962), and include full legal citation information (volume, source, and page) in the reference page: *Baker* v. *Carr*. 1962. 369 U.S. 186.
- *What if I accessed a print article online through a database?* If you use a database like Lexis-Nexis or JSTOR to view a print article, you should cite the article as you would the actual print publication. Since the online version is identical to the print version, I don't care how you accessed it, and you don't need to include a URL.

If you have questions about the APSA method or about a specific citation issue, don't hesitate to ask! It's better to err on the side of caution: failure to cite sources correctly can constitute plagiarism, even if it's the result of simple carelessness!